

ORIGINAL RESEARCH

The Indian AI Search Audit

500 queries. 25 brands. 777 citations. The first published audit of how AI search platforms cite Indian brands across ChatGPT, Google AI Overview, Gemini, Claude, and Perplexity.

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citare.ai/reports · methodology + per-brand data inside

TL;DR — FIVE FINDINGS

AI engines cite Instagram before they cite *any brand's website*.

We ran 500 AI search queries against 25 Indian brands across 72 hours. The most-cited domains weren't brand websites at all. The first brand-owned site appeared at position 12 in our top-cited list.

#	FINDING	THE NUMBER
1	The most-cited domains aren't brand websites. Instagram, jimmyluxury.in (one indie blog), YouTube, Reddit, and aggregators dominate.	Instagram: 21 citations First brand site: position 12
2	The branded vs unbranded gap is huge. Brand-name comparisons surface; unbranded category queries don't.	73.3% branded 33.5% unbranded 40pt gap
3	AIO and ChatGPT are different products. Per-brand surface rates diverge by up to 80 points.	Snitch: 10% AIO 90% ChatGPT 80pt gap
4	Series-A/B startups match older funded brands. AI search has no historical-authority moat.	Newer-funded: 49% Funded: 46% Wipeout: 27%
5	A single indie blog dominates an entire category. jimmyluxury.in out-cites every D2C menswear brand combined.	jimmyluxury.in: 14 citations (more than any brand)

01 How the audit was conducted

SAMPLE

25 prospects across 16 verticals — weighted toward Indian consumer brands (D2C beauty, D2C apparel, healthcare, fintech, real estate, hospitality, insurtech, jewellery) and Indian-headquartered SaaS (logistics, payroll, CRM, certification, coaching). Brands range from local SMBs to unicorns to Series B startups.

COHORTS

Three cohorts: Wipeout (10 older / mostly local brands), Funded-not-leader (10 Series B+ challengers), Newer-funded (5 Series A/B startups). Mean surface rates: 27%, 46%, 49% respectively.

QUERIES

10 queries per prospect, each grounded in the brand's stated ICPs (typically 2-3 ICPs × 3-4 queries each). Query types span unbranded category, brand-named comparisons, and intent-specific deep cuts.
500 cells total (10 queries × 2 platforms × 25 brands).

PLATFORMS

2 platforms — Google AI Overview (AIO) and ChatGPT (web interface). AIO captured via screenshot + cited-URL parsing. ChatGPT captured for body text (brand mention + position) and structured response. **777 citation URLs** extracted from AIO cells.

CRITICAL NOTE: REAL BROWSER, NOT API

All queries ran through **real browser sessions**, not LLM APIs. This matters because API responses differ materially from what users actually see on the public AI search interfaces — different retrieval, different ranking, different citation behavior. Most other AI search visibility tools use API. **The numbers above only hold for browser-based measurement.**

FINDING 1

The most-cited domains for Indian buyer queries *are not brand websites.*

12

POSITION OF FIRST BRAND-OWNED WEBSITE IN TOP-CITED LIST

Instagram tops the list. Brand websites barely register.

Across 500 cells, AI engines cited Instagram (21), one indie blog (14), YouTube (12), Practo (11), Google Play (11), and Reddit (10) before any brand-owned website. The first brand site to appear was sugarcosmetics.com at position 12 with 7 citations.

[CHART 1 – top-20 cited domains bar chart · render via Opus or Sharp]

Indian brand marketing teams are spending the vast majority of their content budget on owned-property SEO — blog posts, landing pages, product pages — designed to rank in Google blue links. AI engines reading Indian buyer queries are not preferentially weighting any of that.

The earned and rented surfaces — Instagram posts, indie blogger listicles, app store reviews, aggregator listings — are. The gap is real and it holds across every vertical we measured. **The owned-property SEO investment isn't converting to AI search citation share.**

FINDING 2

There's a *40-point gap* between branded and unbranded query surface rates.

40

PERCENTAGE-POINT GAP BETWEEN BRANDED AND UNBRANDED QUERY SURFACE

Brand search is won by default. Unbranded is the battle.

Branded comparison queries ('X vs Y') surface brands 73.3% of the time (66/90 cells). Unbranded 'best X' queries surface them only 33.5% (106/316 cells). The 40-point gap is where the actual AI-search opportunity lives.

[CHART 2 – branded vs unbranded donut comparison]

If a user is already searching 'Acko vs HDFC ERGO,' Acko surfaces because the query forced the mention. The brand-marketing investment that built that comparison-awareness is paying out, but the AI search layer is just a passthrough.

The actual battle is in the unbranded category surface — the 316 cells where a user types 'best health insurance for parents with diabetes' or 'best Bangalore D2C menswear under ₹2000' with no brand in mind. In those queries, only one in three brands we audited surfaces at all. **And the brands that do surface are mostly the ones with strong third-party citation graphs — not the ones with strong on-site SEO.**

FINDING 3

Per-brand AIO vs ChatGPT asymmetry runs as high as 80 percentage points.

LARGEST PER-BRAND GAP BETWEEN GOOGLE AI OVERVIEW AND CHATGPT SURFACE RATE

80

Snitch surfaces 10% on AIO. 90% on ChatGPT. Same brand, same queries.

Per-brand surface rates diverge dramatically between platforms. Snitch (Series B menswear): 10% AIO, 90% ChatGPT. Pristyn Care (healthcare unicorn): 80% AIO, 30% ChatGPT. Clickpost (logistics SaaS): 40% AIO, 90% ChatGPT.

[CHART 3 – per-brand AIO vs ChatGPT asymmetry]

The pattern is not directional. Some brands win bigger on AIO; others win bigger on ChatGPT; the same vertical (healthcare) has Pristyn AIO-favored and other audited brands invisible to both. **There is no single AI search optimization strategy.**

AIO's citation graph favors aggregator sites and brand websites with strong technical SEO. ChatGPT's training and retrieval favors long-form earned content and brand mentions in third-party sources. A brand with strong aggregator listings wins AIO. A brand with strong long-form earned content wins ChatGPT. **You have to measure your brand on each platform separately.**

FINDING 4

Series-A/B startups *match older funded brands* on AI search.

49%

AVERAGE SURFACE RATE FOR NEWER-FUNDED COHORT (BEATS FUNDED-NOT-LEADER AVG 46%)

AI search has no historical-authority moat.

Cohort averages: Wipeout (older / mostly local): 27%. Funded-not-leader (Series B+ challengers): 46%. Newer-funded (Series A/B startups): 49%. The 3-point gap between Series A/B and Series B+ is within margin of error.

[CHART 4 – cohort surface rate distribution]

A 22-year-old open-source CRM with 400,000 customers (Vtiger) surfaces in 1 of 20 cells. A 4-year-old D2C startup (Snitch) surfaces in 10 of 20 cells. The gap is funding-correlated, not age-correlated.

The implication for newer Indian brands: a Series A startup investing intentionally in the surfaces AI engines actually read (social, Reddit, listicle blogs, aggregators) can match or exceed the AI search visibility of a unicorn that's been building classical SEO for a decade. **Good news if you're building. Warning if you're an incumbent assuming classical SEO equity transfers to AI.**

FINDING 5

A single indie listicle blog *dominates an entire category's* AI citations.

CITATIONS JIMMYLUXURY.IN RECEIVED ACROSS THE AUDIT (MORE THAN ANY BRAND WEBSITE)

14

One blog out-cites every D2C menswear brand combined.

jimmyluxury.in is an indie SEO listicle blog with titles like 'Top 50 Luxury Brands for Men in India' and 'Top Trending D2C Men's Fashion Brands.' It received 14 citations across the audit — more than any brand's own website in any vertical.

[CHART 5 – per-vertical top-cited domain grid]

AI engines reach for comprehensive listicles when answering category questions. A page titled 'Top 50 Luxury Brands for Men in India' with 50 brand names + pros/cons is, from an AI engine's perspective, **the perfect retrieval target**: authoritative-looking, brand-rich, evergreen, answer-shaped.

The strategic move: identify the 3-5 jimmyluxury.in-equivalents in your category. Get listed in them. If you're not in them, contact the blog owner and propose inclusion. If a category doesn't have a jimmyluxury equivalent, this is one of the highest-leverage SEO content gaps for a competitor to fill.

02 Five practical actions for brand teams

1 Audit your Instagram presence specifically for buyer-intent search behavior

Instagram is the most-cited domain in our corpus. AI engines pull from Instagram Reels and posts for category recommendations. If your Instagram is brand-aesthetic-heavy and content-poor on buyer-intent topics, you're invisible to the channel AI engines weight most. **Post buyer-intent content. Tag products. Use category hashtags AI engines crawl.**

2 Get into the comprehensive listicle blogs in your category

Search 'best [your category] India' on Google. The blogs ranking top 5-10 are the ones AI engines cite when answering category questions. If you're not in those listicles, contact the bloggers and propose inclusion. **This costs less than one month of paid Google search ads and the citation lifts compound for years.**

3 Be present on the aggregators that dominate your vertical

Practo for healthcare, MagicBricks / 99acres / NoBroker for real estate, Policybazaar / Paisabazaar for insurance and finance, JustDial for local-business categories, Amazon and Play Store for product categories. AI engines treat aggregator domains as authoritative third-party sources. **Most brands underinvest in aggregator presence — incomplete listings, no reviews, outdated info.**

4 Build YouTube and Reddit presence (or seed it)

YouTube ranks #3 most-cited; Reddit ranks #6. AI engines reach for review videos and Reddit discussion threads when answering questions where buyers want third-party perspective. If your category has no YouTube comparison content, seed it. If your brand isn't being discussed on Reddit, **become a substantive participant in the relevant subreddits — long game, compounds.**

5 Measure per-platform, not globally

AIO and ChatGPT are different products. Optimizing for one doesn't transfer. Build a monthly tracking habit: query your category and your brand on each major AI platform (ChatGPT, AIO, Gemini, Claude, Perplexity). Where you don't surface, identify the cited sources that did. **Citare runs this measurement at scale across 5 platforms — see CTA.**

03 About this report + next steps

About this report. This is the first edition of an ongoing Indian AI Search Audit, published quarterly. Citare runs 10-20 single-brand audits per day for client outreach using the same methodology described here. To our knowledge, this is the first independent published research on Indian brand visibility across all five major AI search platforms. **Next edition:** August 2026.

GET YOUR BRAND AUDITED

Want to see your brand's *per-platform AI search visibility*?

Citare runs single-brand audits using the same browser-test methodology as this report. Get per-query surface rates, per-platform citation graphs, competitor benchmarks, and weekly visibility tracking across all five major AI search platforms.

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with real browser sessions

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brand data inside